who, although never prime minister, had immense influence as chief of staff, minister of defense, and, in his later days, foreign minister: Moshe Dayan.

In 1966, on a visit to Israel before my appointment at Hebrew University, I met Moshe Dayan and we talked. It was my friend the journalist and later biographer of Ben-Gurion, Shabtai Teveth, who took me on a visit to Moshe in his house in Zahala. He was a private citizen at that time, before becoming a key figure as defense minister in the cabinet that was to launch the chain of victories in the Six-Day War. In the 1950s, he had given a memorable speech at the tomb of a friend killed by a Palestinian infiltrator from Gaza (at the time belonging to Egypt). I have already mentioned how he prognosticated that there would be no peace with the Palestinians and that Israel would have to survive by the sword. I asked him about that.

The Palestinians are peasants whose land we took, he explained, and peasants never forget their land until they have taken it back. It was basic and cogent. For Dayan, living by the sword was nothing to be afraid of. Many years later, after bearing the brunt of popular anger as defense minister during the Yom Kippur War, he became foreign minister in Begin's cabinet and partly engineered the peace with Egypt. Dayan was a loner who didn't mind changing political camps. I guess that he didn't change his views about the Palestinians.

In this gallery, where does Netanyahu stand? I have amply shown in the early diary entries what I, along with 60 or 70 percent of the Israeli population, think of Netanyahu as prime minister, mainly as far as internal politics are concerned: he is a despicable self-serving type who, in order to save his skin, has been ready to set up a religious ultranationalist coalition with catastrophic results for the country. Insofar as he has backed the settlers' program, Netanyahu has been ready to endanger the precarious balance of relations with the Palestine Authority to keep his coalition afloat.